

Microsoft Sentinel and Defender Rules Cheat Sheet

This cheat sheet summarizes the main types of rules used in Microsoft Sentinel and Microsoft Defender XDR, including what each rule is for, what triggers it, what it creates (if anything), and its dependencies or prerequisites.

Rule Type	Purpose / Use Case	Triggered By	Creates / Outputs	Depends On / Prerequisite	Notes
Analytics Rule	Detect threats from logs using KQL query logic	Scheduled runs or custom schedule	Alerts	Data connectors, KQL logic	Core detection logic in Sentinel. Alerts feed into incidents.
Automation Rule	Automate response actions when alerts or incidents are created	Alert or Incident created	Actions (e.g., playbooks)	Alert or incident must already exist	Cannot run before alert or incident. Often used for incident tagging, closing, etc.
Advanced Hunting Detection Rule	Detect custom behaviors across Defender data using hunting queries	Query match on scheduled runs	Alerts	KQL query + Defender XDR environment	Similar to Analytics Rule but in Defender. Can raise alerts from hunting queries.
Threat Analytics Email Rule	Notify security teams when new threat intel is published	Threat Analytics publication	Email notifications	Threat Analytics enabled	Tracks new threat reports tied to vulnerabilities or attack types.
Vulnerability Email Rule	Alert about new known vulnerabilities on devices	Device vulnerability assessment	Email notifications	Threat and vulnerability mgmt enabled	Helps with patch management and prioritization.
Alert Email Notification Rule	Notify via email when Defender alerts are triggered	Defender alert creation	Email notifications	Defender alerting enabled	Basic alert-to-email pipeline for security teams.

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Live Response Automation Rule	Run remediation scripts or collect data automatically on endpoints	Trigger from alerts or incidents	Remediation actions	Defender for Endpoint and devices	Can collect logs, kill processes, isolate device, etc.
Device Group Rule	Group devices by tags or criteria for targeting policies	Device onboarding or tag change	Device assignment	Device tags or filters	Helps apply different baselines or settings by group.
Watchlist-based Logic	Not a rule itself, but used in other rules to compare known bad/good values	Referenced in Analytics or Hunting queries	Depends on usage	Populated watchlist	Use for dynamic lists (IPs, users, hashes). Enhances detection logic.

Let me know if you'd like to add visuals or walk through examples of how to configure or test any of these in your lab!